

partner is not important, but their specifications are primary. In that case, we keep in mind their demands and find them a suitable partner with the defined expertise. Like in some cases, the customers want to have partners who have done a lot of government projects—while for others, the requirement may be that the partner should have an office in their base city. Whatever the case may be, we find them the right partner, depending upon their demands.

I think all open source projects are disorganised—and that's the beauty of open source!

So, essentially, we have partners involved in the website building. We have over 300 partners around the world. We intend to expand the partner network considerably next year, not just in India, but in other countries around the world. We get a good number of queries on our website from customers, which we pass on to our partners to be attended to.

Drupal and India...

Q How do you plan to expand your training program in India?

We have already been doing some training in India. One of the reasons for this trip is to understand the state of Drupal in India and what the needs of the community here are. One of the things we have discovered from the interactions we had is the strong desire for training, both from small Drupal shops and the large SIs. Everybody has expressed a desire to get expert training in Drupal. We work with a lot of training partners as well. We have a lot of small Drupal shops. We have found that the demand for trained Drupal professionals does not match the supply at all.

Q So do you offer a certification course for Drupal?

Right now, we have some full-time staff at Acquia to build and maintain the training curriculum. We provide expert training in all Drupal aspects. We are using that training material and sharing it with all our partners. We are also training the trainers effectively. We help our partners impart that training, because we feel it is more scalable and that's how we can reach thousands of Drupal people. We do not have any formal certification in place, but I think that it is only a matter of time before either we do that as a company, or someone else from the community does it. At some point of time, the demand for trained Drupal professionals will be so large that this will become a necessity.

Q So how do you plan to scale up training in India? Who are your partners here and how do you plan to grow amongst them?

If you look at North America and Europe, Drupal basically grew there for two reasons. First, a lot of developers

and engineers working for bigger organisations started organising Drupal meet-ups and camps. That's one of the things I would want to promote here. One of the main reasons of this trip is that we want to help people organise these camps. We are also trying to take the 'top-to-down approach'. We are meeting up with the partners and exploring possibilities as to how can they take it up more effectively. We already have 8-10 stronger partners and we are also working with larger SIs. Some of them are doing architecture work, development work and training. So we already have 2-3 training partners in India.

Q Have you set any target regarding how many people you plan to train in a given period?

We are here to gauge how big the domain really is. We would like to work with as many Indian partners as possible. Clearly, there is a demand for thousands of trained Drupal professionals. Now we have to see how to cater to that kind of demand. This is the reason why Drupal training in India is so important. The biggest challenge is to find Drupal developers and trained Drupal professionals. This is one of the biggest hindrances for the growth of Drupal adoption in India, so there is a huge opportunity for every engineer in India to get involved in Drupal.

Q How many hits do you see from India on the Drupal website?

Last time I checked, which has been a couple of months ago, Indians were actually the second biggest group of visitors to the Drupal website. I am sure they still are. The first group was North Americans. The Indian traffic for Drupal continues to grow, which is one of the major reasons why we are here. We saw the interest from the Drupal community.

Q What about Drupal's physical presence in India?

With this visit, we will gauge the temperature of Drupal in India. We will take some time to decide whether we need a presence in India or if our presence will help the Drupal community in some way. We have understood so far that it will clearly help if we have some people in India.

Q Are you aware that Google has recently launched a service where it facilitates SMEs. The company plans to develop about 500,000 websites for SMEs in India. Users just need to go to an online location, where they can create their website in three simple steps. Does this kind of a format, coming from a giant, pose a challenge for Drupal?

It's hard to tell what its impact will be, right now. I have heard about it but not tried it. But I can imagine it allows you to create pretty basic websites. I think where Drupal will shine is in building more sophisticated and feature-rich websites. A lot of SMEs will actually find that at some point in time, they would like to use all of those features. The Google platform is good to bring people onto the Web, to get them